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On the Psalms

A Letter to Marcellinus

ATHANASIUS OF ALEXANDRIA

Epistula ad Marcellinum, Patrologia Graeca 27, cols. 11-46

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This is a new translation, made from the Greek text printed in Migne's Patrologia Graeca, vol. 27 (1857). Athanasius quotes the Psalms from the Greek Bible; the quotations are translated as he gives them. Psalm numbers follow English Bibles. In four places the printed Greek gives a psalm number that is plainly a copying slip (Ps. 105 for 15, Ps. 17 for 18, Ps. 41 for 47, and one unreadable number in the list of psalms of praise); the intended psalm is given, and the unreadable number is left out. The section headings are the editor's.

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ABOUT THIS BOOKLET

Athanasius (c. 296-373) was bishop of Alexandria for forty-five years and spent nearly twenty of them in exile, five times driven out for defending the faith of Nicaea, that the Son is truly God. He is remembered for *On the Incarnation* and for his *Life of Antony*, which made the desert monks known to the whole Church.

This letter is gentler. A friend, Marcellinus, has been ill and is reading the Psalms closely, trying to grasp the meaning of each one. Athanasius answers by passing on what a wise old man once taught him. The Psalter, the old man says, holds the whole of Scripture in song; it is a mirror of the soul; and unlike the rest of Scripture, its words can be spoken as our own. Then he does something no one had done before: he goes through life's troubles and joys one by one and names the psalm to pray in each.

Read it slowly, with a Bible open. When a psalm is named, turn to it.

This is the first booklet in the collection *On Prayer*.

The English versions in print are still under copyright, so this booklet has its own, made from the Greek. It aims to be plain and faithful rather than elegant.

Psalm numbers. Athanasius used the Greek Bible, whose numbering of the Psalms runs one behind ours for most of the book. The numbers here have been changed to match English Bibles, so you can look them up directly.

Psalm wording. His quotations follow the Greek, so they will sometimes read differently from your Bible. Psalm 151, which he mentions, is found only in the Greek Bible.

"The Jews." Where Athanasius writes of the plot of "the Jews" against Jesus, he means, as the Gospels do, those who sought his death. The translation keeps his words.

The old man. Most of the letter is his teaching, reported by Athanasius; the voice changes only at the beginning and, briefly, near the end.

The headings in italics are the editor's, added to help you find your way. The letter itself runs on without them.

The Letter

I admire you, my dear Marcellinus, for the way you have chosen in Christ. You are bearing your present trial well, though it has cost you much suffering, and you have not let your discipline slip. When I asked the man who brought your letter how you were getting on now that your illness is past, I learned that you give your time to the whole of the divine Scripture, but that you read the Book of Psalms most often of all, and work hard to grasp the meaning that lies in each psalm.

For this I welcome you warmly, for I too have a great love for that book, as for all of Scripture. Being of that mind, I once met an old man who had given himself to long study, and I want to write down for you what he told me about the Psalter, which he knew well. His account has a certain grace and persuasiveness, and good sense besides. This is what he said:

The whole of Scripture in one book

My child, all our Scripture, old and new, is inspired by God and useful for teaching, as it is written. But the Book of Psalms holds something worth noticing for those who pay attention. Each book of Scripture serves and announces its own subject. The five books of Moses tell of the making of the world, the deeds of the patriarchs, Israel's going out of Egypt, and the ordering of the Law. The three books that follow tell of the dividing of the land, the deeds of the judges, and the family line of David. The books of Kings and Chronicles tell the deeds of the kings; Ezra, the release from captivity, the people's return, and the rebuilding of the temple and the city. The Prophets foretell the coming of the Saviour, call the commandments to mind, rebuke those who break them, and prophesy to the nations.

But the Book of Psalms is like a garden. It holds all of these things and sets them to music, and alongside them it shows things of its own, which it sings as well.

It sings of what is in Genesis in Psalm 19:

> The heavens tell the glory of God, and the firmament proclaims the work of his hands.

And in Psalm 24:

> The earth is the Lord's, and all that fills it, the world and all who dwell in it; he founded it upon the seas.

It sings well of what is in Exodus, Numbers and Deuteronomy, in Psalm 78 and in Psalm 114, where it says:

> When Israel went out of Egypt, the house of Jacob from a people of strange speech, Judah became his sanctuary, Israel his dominion.

And it sings of the same things in Psalm 105:

> He sent Moses his servant, and Aaron, whom he had chosen. He set among them the words of his signs and of his wonders in the land of Ham. He sent darkness, and it grew dark; and they rebelled against his words. He turned their waters into blood and killed their fish. Their land swarmed with frogs, even in the chambers of their kings. He spoke, and there came flies and gnats throughout all their borders.

Indeed, you will find this whole psalm, and Psalm 106 as well, written about the same events. What concerns the priesthood and the tabernacle it proclaims in Psalm 29, which is sung at the going out of the tabernacle:

> Bring to the Lord, you sons of God, bring to the Lord young rams; bring to the Lord glory and honour.

What happened under Joshua the son of Nun and under the Judges it shows, in a way, in Psalm 107, when it says, ‘They founded cities to live in, sowed fields and planted vineyards’; for it was under Joshua that the

promised land was given out to them. And when, in the same psalm, it says again and again, 'They cried to the Lord in their trouble, and he saved them from their distress,' it points to the Book of Judges: for in those days, when they cried out, he raised up judges at the right time and saved the people from those who oppressed them.

It sings in a way of the Kings in Psalm 20, saying:

> Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we will be made great in the name of the Lord our God. They were bound and fell, but we have risen and stand upright. O Lord, save the king, and hear us on the day we call upon you.

What concerns Ezra it sings in Psalm 126, one of the Songs of Ascents: 'When the Lord turned back the captivity of Zion, we were like those who are comforted'; and again in Psalm 122:

> I was glad when they said to me, Let us go to the house of the Lord. Our feet were standing within your courts, O Jerusalem. Jerusalem, built as a city that is bound firmly together; for there the tribes went up, the tribes of the Lord, a testimony for Israel.

And what is in the Prophets it signals in nearly every psalm. Of the Saviour's coming, and that it is God himself who will come, it says in Psalm 50, 'The Lord will come openly, our God, and will not keep silence'; and

in Psalm 118, 'Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord; we have blessed you from the house of the Lord. The Lord is God, and he has appeared to us.' That he is the Word of the Father, it sings in Psalm 107: 'He sent his Word and healed them, and delivered them from their ruin.' For the God who comes is himself the Word who is sent. And knowing that this Word is the Son of God, it sings the voice of the Father in Psalm 45, 'My heart has poured forth a good Word,' and again in Psalm 110, 'From the womb, before the morning star, I have begotten you.' What else could one call the Father's offspring but his Word and his Wisdom? And knowing that it was to him that the Father said, 'Let there be light,' and 'Let there be a firmament,' and all the rest, this book also holds the words, 'By the Word of the Lord the heavens were made firm, and all their host by the breath of his mouth.'

Nor was it ignorant that he would come as the Christ. It speaks of this above all in Psalm 45:

> Your throne, O God, is for ever and ever; the sceptre of your kingdom is a sceptre of uprightness. You have loved righteousness and hated iniquity; therefore God, your God, has anointed you with the oil of gladness above your companions.

And so that no one should think he would come only in appearance, it makes clear that he would become

man, and that he is the one through whom all things were made. It says in Psalm 87, 'Mother Zion shall say, A man, and a man was born in her; and the Most High himself founded her.' This is the same as saying, 'And the Word was God; all things were made through him; and the Word became flesh.'

Knowing too that he would be born of a virgin, it did not keep silent, but gives a sign of it at once in Psalm 45, saying:

> Hear, O daughter, and see, and incline your ear; forget your own people and your father's house, for the king has desired your beauty.

This again is like what Gabriel said: 'Hail, you who are full of grace, the Lord is with you.' For having called him the Christ, the psalm at once makes known his human birth from the Virgin, saying, 'Hear, O daughter.' Notice: Gabriel calls Mary by her name, since by birth he is a stranger to her; but David, from whose seed she comes, rightly calls her his daughter.

Having said that he would become man, it goes on to show that he would suffer in the flesh. Seeing the plot the Jews would lay against him, it sings in Psalm 2:

> Why did the nations rage, and the peoples plot in vain? The kings of the earth took their stand, and the rulers gathered together against the Lord and against his Christ.

And in Psalm 22 it tells, in the Saviour's own voice, what kind of death it would be:

> You have brought me down into the dust of death. For many dogs have surrounded me; a gang of evildoers has closed in on me. They have pierced my hands and my feet; they have counted all my bones. They stared and gazed at me; they divided my garments among them, and for my clothing they cast lots.

To say that his hands and feet were pierced, what else is it but to point to the cross?

Having taught all this, it adds that the Lord suffers these things not for his own sake but for ours. Speaking again in his voice, it says in Psalm 88, 'Your wrath has rested heavily upon me,' and in Psalm 69, 'What I did not steal, I had to repay.' For he did not die as one who owed it; he suffered for us, and carried in himself the wrath that was against us because of our transgression, as he says through Isaiah: 'He took our weaknesses upon himself.' So we say, in Psalm 138, 'The Lord will repay on my behalf'; and the Spirit says in Psalm 72, 'He will save the children of the needy and humble the oppressor; for he delivered the poor from the hand of the powerful, and the needy one who had no helper.'

For this reason it also foretells his bodily ascent into heaven. It says in Psalm 24, ‘Lift up your gates, you rulers, and be lifted up, you everlasting doors, and the King of glory shall come in’; and in Psalm 47, ‘God has gone up with a shout, the Lord with the sound of the trumpet.’ It announces his sitting at the right hand, and says in Psalm 110, ‘The Lord said to my Lord, Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies the footstool of your feet’; and in Psalm 9 it cries out the ruin that came upon the devil: ‘You have sat upon the throne, you who judge with righteousness; you have rebuked the nations, and the ungodly one has perished.’

Nor did it hide that he received all judgment from the Father, but foretells that he will come as judge of all. In Psalm 72 it says, ‘O God, give your judgment to the king, and your righteousness to the king’s son, to judge your people with righteousness and your poor with justice’; and in Psalm 50, ‘He will call to the heavens above and to the earth, to judge his people. And the heavens will declare his righteousness,

for God is judge’; and in Psalm 82, ‘God has taken his place in the assembly of gods; in their midst he will judge between gods.’

The calling of the Gentiles too can be learned from this book in many places, but above all from Psalm 47,

‘Clap your hands, all you nations; shout to God with a voice of joy,’ and from Psalm 72:

> The Ethiopians will fall down before him, and his enemies will lick the dust. The kings of Tarshish and of the islands will bring gifts; the kings of Arabia and Sheba will offer presents. All the kings of the earth will bow down to him; all the nations will serve him.

These things are sung in the Psalms, and they are foretold in each of the other books as well.

He knew, he said, that in every book of Scripture the same things are made known about the Saviour in a special way. This is the message common to them all, the one harmony of the Spirit. For just as you can find what belongs to the other books in this one, so what belongs to this one is often found in the others. Moses writes a song, Isaiah sings, and Habakkuk prays with a song. And in every book you can see prophecy and law and history. For it is the same Spirit over all. According to the share the Spirit gives to each, each serves and fulfils the grace given to him, whether it is prophecy, or law-giving, or the remembrance of history, or the grace of the psalms. But since it is one and the same Spirit from whom all the gifts are shared out, while he himself by nature is undivided, the whole is present in each, and the gifts and showings of the Spirit come to each as their service requires. So each,

as the need arises, often serves the word as the Spirit supplies it. That is why, as I said, Moses the lawgiver sometimes prophesies and sings; and the prophets, while prophesying, sometimes give commands, as in 'Wash yourselves, be clean,' and 'Wash your heart from wickedness, O Jerusalem'; and sometimes they tell history, as Daniel tells the story of Susanna, and Isaiah tells of the Rabshakeh and Sennacherib. In the same way the Book of Psalms, whose own particular gift is song, sings in broad and tuneful voice what the other books set out at length, as I have said. It too gives laws at times: 'Leave off from anger, and forsake wrath,' and 'Turn away from evil and do good; seek peace and pursue it.' At times it tells the history of Israel's journey, and it prophesies about the Saviour, as was said before.

So let this grace of the Spirit be common to all of them; let it be found in each, and the same in all, as need demands and as the Spirit wills. In this service more or less makes no difference, so long as each fulfils and completes his own ministry without slackening.

A mirror of the soul

Yet even so, the Book of Psalms has a grace of its own, and something about it that deserves special notice. Besides all that it shares with the other books, it has

this marvel of its own: the movements of every soul, with their changes and their correction, are written out and portrayed in it. So anyone who wishes may find in it, as from a boundless store, the pattern by which to shape himself, for it is all written there.

In the other books one only hears the law commanding what should be done and what should not; one listens to the prophecies, only so as to know of the Saviour's coming; one pays attention to the histories, from which one can learn the deeds of the kings and of the saints. But in the Book of Psalms, besides learning these things, the hearer also comes to understand the movements of his own soul and is taught by them. Whatever he is suffering, whatever holds him in its grip, he can find in this book an image of the words that fit it. So he does not merely hear and pass on, but learns how to heal his trouble by what he says and does.

The other books also contain words that forbid what is evil; but in this book is set out how to keep away from it. For example, there is the command to repent, and to repent is to stop sinning; but here is set out how to repent, and what to say in repenting. Again, Paul said, 'Affliction produces patience in the soul, and patience proven character, and proven character hope, and hope does not put us to shame.' But in the

Psalms it is written and engraved how one should bear afflictions, what one should say while afflicted and what after the affliction, how each person is tested, and what the words are of those who hope in the Lord. Again, there is the command to give thanks in everything; but the Psalms teach us what to say when we give thanks. Then we hear from others that 'all who want to live a godly life will be persecuted'; from the Psalms we are taught what to cry out when we flee, and what words to offer God while we are persecuted and after we have been delivered. We are told to bless the Lord and to confess him; but in the Psalms we are shown how to praise the Lord, and with what words we may fittingly confess him. And in every case one would find these divine songs suited to us, set out for our own movements and states of soul.

Words that become our own

There is this further wonder in the Psalms. In the other books, those who read aloud what the saints say, and what they say it about, are reporting things written about other people; and those who listen think of themselves as different from the people the words describe. The deeds they hear of move them at most to admire and to wish to imitate. But whoever takes up this book goes through the prophecies about the

Saviour with wonder and worship, as he does in the other Scriptures, while the other psalms he reads as if they were his own words. And the one who hears them is moved to the heart as though he himself were speaking, and takes the words of the songs to himself as though they were his.

For clearness' sake I must not shrink, as the blessed Apostle says, from saying the same thing again. The patriarchs spoke many words, words that were properly their own. Moses spoke, and God answered him. Elijah and Elisha, sitting on Mount Carmel, called upon the Lord and always said, 'As the Lord lives, before whom I stand today.' The words of the other holy prophets are first of all about the Saviour, and many of them were spoken to the nations and to Israel. Yet no one would ever speak the patriarchs' words as his own, nor would anyone dare to copy Moses' very words and say them, nor the words of Abraham or Elijah, as if they were his. Even if someone shares the sufferings of the sufferers, and is seized at times by longing for what is better, he would never say with Moses, 'Show yourself to me,' or again, 'If you will forgive their sin, forgive it; but if not, blot me out of the book you have written.' Nor would anyone take the words of the prophets as his own, to blame or praise those who do what the prophets blamed or

praised; nor would anyone presume to say, as his own words, 'As the Lord lives, before whom I stand today.' Whoever reads those books plainly speaks the words not as his own, but as the words of the saints and of those they speak about.

But the psalms, and this is the wonder, are different. Apart from the prophecies about the Saviour and the nations, whoever recites them speaks the rest as his own words. Each person sings them as if they had been written about himself. He does not take them up and recite them as if someone else were speaking, or as if they described someone else; he takes them to heart as though he were speaking of himself. Whatever the words say, he offers to God as if he had done it and were speaking from his own heart. He will not hold back from these words in awe, as he does from the words of the patriarchs and Moses and the other prophets. On the contrary, the one who sings them speaks them boldly, as his own and as written about himself. For the Psalms take in both the one who keeps the commandment and the one who breaks it, and what each of them does; and every person is bound to be found among them, and to say the words written for one or the other, as one who has kept the commandment or as one who has broken it.

It seems to me that for the one who sings them, these words become a kind of mirror, in which he sees himself and the movements of his own soul, and, perceiving them, puts them into words. The one who hears another read receives the song as spoken about himself. Either his conscience convicts him, and he is pierced to the heart and repents; or he hears of the hope that is in God and of the help that comes to those who believe, and he rejoices as if that grace had been given to him, and begins to give thanks to God. So when someone sings Psalm 3 with his own troubles in view, he thinks of the words in the psalm as his own. Then he will say Psalm 12 and Psalm 17 as the expression of his own trust and his own prayer; and Psalm 51, as if he were speaking the words of his own repentance. And when someone sings Psalms 54, 56, 57 and 142, he does not sing as if another were being persecuted; he takes them to heart as the one who is suffering, and sings these words to the Lord as his own.

In short, every psalm has been spoken and composed by the Spirit in such a way that in them, as I said before, the movements of our soul can be seen; and they are all spoken as if about us, and are ours, as our own words, to remind us of the movements within us and to set our way of life right. For what those

who sang the psalms said can become a pattern and a likeness for us as well.

The grace of the Saviour

This again is the Saviour's grace. Having become man for our sake, he offered his own body to death on our behalf, to free us all from death. And wishing to show us the heavenly life that is pleasing to God, he gave it shape in himself, so that we should no longer be easily deceived by the enemy, since we hold as our pledge of safety the victory he won over the devil on our behalf. That is why he did not only teach, but also did what he taught; so that each one might hear him speaking, and, looking on him as on an image, take from him the example of how to act, hearing him say, 'Learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart.' No one could find a more perfect teaching in virtue than the one the Lord gave shape to in himself. Patience, love for humankind, goodness, courage, mercy, righteousness: you will find them all in him, so that nothing is lacking in virtue to anyone who looks closely at this human life of his. Paul knew this when he said, 'Be imitators of me, as I am of Christ.' The lawgivers among the Greeks have a gift that goes no further than speaking. But the Lord, being truly Lord of all and caring for what he has made, not only gives the law but has given

himself as the pattern, so that those who wish may know the power to do it.

That is why, even before his coming among us, he made this sound in the singers of the psalms: so that just as in himself he shaped and showed the earthly and heavenly man, so from the Psalms anyone who wishes may learn the movements and dispositions of souls, and find in them the healing and correction of each movement.

To put it more plainly still: all of divine Scripture is a teacher of virtue and true faith, but the Book of Psalms holds, in a way, the very image of how souls should live. Someone going in to see a king prepares both his bearing and his words, so as not to be thrown out as ill-mannered for speaking otherwise. In the same way this divine book first reminds the one who is running after virtue, and who wants to understand the life the Saviour lived in the body, of the movements of his own soul as he reads, and so it shapes and teaches those who take up such words.

The kinds of psalms

To notice this first about the book: some psalms are spoken as narrative, some as exhortation, some as prophecy, some as prayer, and some as confession and thanksgiving.

Spoken as narrative are Psalms 19, 44, 49, 50, 73, 77, 78, 89, 107, 114-115, 127 and 137.

Spoken as prayer are Psalms 17, 68, 90, 102, 132 and 142. Spoken as petition, prayer and supplication together are Psalms 5, 6, 7, 12, 13, 16, 25, 28, 31, 35, 38, 43, 54, 55, 56, 57, 59, 60, 61, 64, 83, 86, 88, 138, 140 and 143. Psalm 139 is spoken as petition and thanksgiving; and as petition alone, Psalms 3, 26, 69, 70, 71, 74, 79, 80, 109, 123, 130 and 131.

Spoken as confession and thanks are Psalms 9, 75, 92, 105, 106, 107, 108, 111, 118, 136 and 138. Those that weave thanksgiving together with narrative are Psalms 9, 75, 106, 107, 118 and 138; and Psalm 111 weaves thanksgiving and narrative together with praise.

Psalm 37 is spoken as exhortation. Spoken as prophecy are Psalms 21, 22, 45, 47 and 76; and Psalm 110 declares and prophesies at once. Those that urge and call us on are Psalms 29, 33, 81, 95, 96, 97, 98, 103, 104 and 114-115; and Psalm 149 urges us on with song.

Those that describe the life of virtue are Psalms 15, 112, 119, 125 and 133. Those that announce praise are Psalms 113, 117, 135, 145, 146, 147, 148 and 150. The psalms of thanksgiving are Psalms 8, 9, 18, 34, 46, 63, 77, 85, 116, 121, 122, 124, 126, 129 and 144. Those that

proclaim someone blessed are Psalms 1, 32, 41, 119 and 128.

Psalm 108 shows a ready heart, with song. Psalm 81 urges to courage. Those that accuse the ungodly and lawless are Psalms 2, 14, 36, 52 and 53. Psalm 4 is a calling upon God. Psalms 20 and 64 speak good wishes. Those that speak words of boasting in the Lord are Psalms 23, 27, 39, 40, 42, 62, 76, 84, 97 and 99, and the Psalm numbered 151. Those that put to shame are Psalms 58 and 82. Psalms 48 and 65 speak the words of a hymn. Psalm 66 is a shout of joy, and speaks of the resurrection; and Psalm 100 speaks only the words of a joyful shout.

A psalm for every need

Since this is how the Psalms are arranged, those who read them can find in each, as I said, the movements and state of their own soul, and so the pattern and teaching that fit each case: what words they may say to please the Lord, and by what words they may correct themselves and give thanks to the Lord, so that no one falls into ungodliness by speaking otherwise than these words. For we must give an account to the Judge not only for our deeds but for every idle word.

So if you want to call someone blessed, you have in Psalms 1, 32, 41, 112, 119 and 128 how to do it, on what grounds, and what to say.

If you want to rebuke the plot of the Jews against the Saviour, you have the second psalm.

If you are persecuted by your own family, and many rise up against you, say Psalm 3. If you have called upon the Lord in such trouble and been heard, and want to give thanks, sing Psalm 4, and Psalms 75 and 116. And if you see evildoers still wanting to lie in wait for you, and you want your prayer to be heard, rise early in the morning and sing Psalm 5.

If you sense the Lord's threat and see that it troubles you, you can say Psalms 6 and 38.

If people are plotting against you, as Ahithophel plotted against David, and someone tells you of it, sing Psalm 7, and take courage in God who rescues you.

When you see the Saviour's grace spread out everywhere and the human race saved, and you want to speak to the Lord, sing Psalm 8. Or again, if you want to sing a song of the winepress, giving thanks to the Lord, you have Psalm 8 again, and Psalm 84.

For the defeat of the enemy and the saving of creation, do not boast in yourself; knowing that it was the Son

of God who accomplished it, say Psalm 9, which was spoken of him.

If someone is set on troubling you, keep your trust in the Lord and sing Psalm 11.

When you see the pride of the many and wickedness spreading, so that nothing holy remains among people, take refuge in the Lord and say Psalm 12.

If the plotting of your enemies drags on, do not lose heart as though God had forgotten you, but call on the Lord, singing Psalm 13.

When you hear people blaspheming against God's providence, have no share in their ungodliness, but plead with God and say Psalms 14 and 53.

If you want to learn what kind of person is a citizen of the kingdom of heaven, sing Psalm 15.

If you need to pray because of those who stand against you and surround your soul, sing Psalms 17, 86, 87 and 141. If you want to learn how Moses prayed, you have Psalm 90. Have you been saved from your enemies and delivered from those who pursued you? Then you too sing Psalm 18.

Do you marvel at the order of creation, at the grace of providence within it, and at the holy precepts of the Law? Sing Psalms 19 and 24.

When you see people in distress, comfort them, praying for them and saying to them the words of Psalm 20.

Do you see yourself shepherded and led on a good road by the Lord? Rejoice in it and sing Psalm 23.

Your enemies are all around you; but lift up your soul to God and say Psalm 25, and you will see them sin in vain.

If your enemies persist, with nothing in their hands but blood, seeking to drag you down and destroy you, do not hand the judgment over to any human being, for all human judgments are open to suspicion. Ask God to be the judge, for he alone is just, and say the words of Psalm 26, and Psalms 35 and 43.

If they press on more fiercely, and your enemies grow into a crowd like an army camp, despising you as if you had not yet been anointed, and so wanting to make war on you, do not cower, but sing Psalm 27.

And since human nature is weak, if those who plot against you grow shameless again, cry out to God, so that you need not spend your time on them, and say the words of Psalm 28.

If, in giving thanks, you want to learn how you should make an offering to the Lord, understanding it in a spiritual sense, sing Psalm 29.

And when you dedicate your house, both your soul, which receives the Lord, and the bodily house in which you live in the body, give thanks and say Psalm 30, and Psalm 127 from the Songs of Ascents.

When you see yourself hated and persecuted for the truth's sake by all your friends and relatives, do not lose heart over them or over yourself; and if you see those who know you turning away from you, do not cower, but stand back from them, look to what is to come, and sing Psalm 31.

When you see people being baptized and set free from this perishable birth, and you marvel at God's love for humankind, sing Psalm 32 over them.

When you want to sing with many others, gather the righteous and those whose lives are upright, and say Psalm 33.

If you have fallen among enemies, escaped them by good sense, and slipped out of their plot, and you want to give thanks, call together the gentle and sing Psalm 34 in their company.

If you see the lawless competing in evil, do not think that wickedness is in them by nature, as the heretics say; but say Psalm 36, and you will see that they themselves are the cause of their sinning.

If you see the wicked doing much that is lawless and lifting themselves up against the lowly, and you want to warn someone not to pay them heed or envy them, since they will quickly be destroyed, say Psalm 37, both to yourself and to others.

But if you have resolved to watch over yourself, and you see the enemy attacking you (for it is then that he rises up most against such people), and you want to strengthen yourself against him, sing Psalm 39.

If your enemies attack and you endure the afflictions, and you want to learn the benefit of patience, sing Psalm 40.

When you see many who are poor and in need and you want them to receive mercy, you can commend those who have already shown mercy and urge the others to do the same by saying Psalm 41.

If, while you are full of longing for God, you hear your enemies taunting you, do not be troubled. Understand the undying fruit of such longing, encourage your soul with hope in God, and so lighten and soothe its sorrows in this life, saying Psalm 42.

If you want to keep remembering the good things God did for our fathers, the going out from Egypt and the time in the desert, and how God is good while human

beings are ungrateful, you have Psalms 44, 78, 89, 105, 106, 107 and 114-115.

If you have taken refuge in God and been brought safely through the troubles that surrounded you, and you want to give thanks to God and tell of his kindness to you, you have Psalm 46.

But have you sinned, and in your shame do you repent and ask for mercy? You have the words of confession and repentance in Psalm 51.

If you have been slandered before a wicked king, and you see the devil boasting over you, withdraw, and you too say the words of Psalm 52.

When you are persecuted, and people slander you, wanting to hand you over, as the Ziphites and the Philistines did to David, do not lose heart, but take courage in the Lord, sing his praise, and say the words of Psalms 54 and 56.

And if your pursuer catches up with you, and without knowing it comes into the very cave where you are hiding, do not cower even then. For you have, for such straits, the sayings that give comfort and the words inscribed for remembrance in Psalms 57 and 142.

If the one who plots against you orders your house to be watched, and you escape, give the thanks to the Lord, writing it on your soul as on a pillar, as a

memorial that you were not destroyed, and say the words of Psalm 59.

If your enemies taunt and afflict you, and those who seem to be your friends slander you with idle talk, and you are grieved for a while in your thoughts, you can still take comfort by singing praise to God and saying the words of Psalm 55.

Against those who play the hypocrite and boast to your face, say Psalm 58, to put them to shame. Against those who rush at you savagely and want to take your life, set your submission to God, and take courage. The more they rage, the more you submit to the Lord, and say the words of Psalm 62.

If, when you are persecuted, you go off into the desert, do not be afraid as though you were alone there. You have God there; rise early to him and sing Psalm 63.

If your enemies try to frighten you, and never stop lying in wait for you, but search out everything against you, do not give way, even if they are many. Their blows will be like the arrows of children, while you sing Psalms 64, 65, 70 and 71.

When you want to sing a hymn to the Lord, sing the words of Psalm 65. If you want to teach someone about the resurrection, sing the words of Psalm 66. When

you ask God for his mercy, praise him by singing Psalm 67.

When you see the ungodly at peace and prospering, living as they please, while the righteous are afflicted, say the words of Psalm 73, so that you are not caused to stumble or shaken.

When God is angry with his people, you have wise words of comfort for it in Psalm 74. When you need to give thanks and confess him, sing Psalms 9, 75, 92, 105, 106, 107, 108, 111, 118, 136 and 138.

If you want to put to shame the teachings of the pagans and the heretics, since the knowledge of God is not with them but only in the catholic Church, you can sing and say, with understanding, the words of Psalm 76.

If your enemies have cut off every way of escape and you are hard pressed, then even if you are troubled, do not despair, but pray; and if you cry out and are heard, give thanks to God, saying the words of Psalm 77.

If your enemies persist and break in, defile the house of God, kill the saints and throw their bodies to the birds of the air, do not be dragged down into cowering before their cruelty, but suffer with those who suffer, and plead with God, saying Psalm 79.

At a feast, when you want to sing to the Lord, call together the servants of God and sing the words of Psalms 81 and 95.

If your enemies again gather from every side, threaten the house of God and make pacts against true religion, do not lose heart at their number and power: you have the words of Psalm 83 as an anchor of hope.

If, as you look on the house of God and his eternal dwellings, you long for them as the Apostle did, you too say Psalm 84.

When at last the wrath has ceased and the captivity is ended, and you want to give thanks, you have the words of Psalms 85 and 126 to say.

If you want to know how the catholic Church differs from the schisms, and to put them to shame, you can say what is written in Psalm 87.

If you want to encourage yourself and others in reverence for God, and to show that hope in God does not put us to shame but makes the soul fearless, praise God with the words of Psalm 91.

Do you want to sing on the Sabbath? You have Psalm 92. Do you want to give thanks on the Lord's day? You have Psalm 24. Do you want to sing on the second day of the week? Say the words of Psalm 48. Do you want to give praise on the day of Preparation? You have the

praise in Psalm 93. For it was then, when the cross took place, that the house of God was built, though the enemies tried to prevent it; and so on that day it is fitting to sing to God the victory song spoken in Psalm 93. If after a captivity the house is pulled down and then built again, sing the words of Psalm 96. When the land has found rest from those who made war on it, and is at peace at last, and the Lord reigns, if you want to sing of this, you have Psalm 97. Do you want to sing on the fourth day of the week? You have Psalm 94. For it was then that the Lord, being betrayed, began to carry out his judgment against death and to triumph over it openly. So when you read in the Gospel that on the fourth day of the week the Jews took counsel against the Lord, and you see him then acting boldly in judgment against the devil on your behalf, sing the words of Psalm 94.

Again, when you see the Lord's providence over all things and his lordship, and you want to instruct someone in faith and obedience to him, first persuading them to give him thanks, sing Psalm 100. And if, having learned his power to judge, and that the Lord judges with mercy mixed into his judgment, you want to draw near to him, you have the words of Psalm 101 for that.

Since our nature is weak, if the pressures of life ever leave you poor and dispirited and you want comfort, you have Psalm 102.

And since it is fitting for us to give thanks to God through all things and in everything, when you want to bless him, you have Psalms 103 and 104 to stir up your soul and to say.

Do you want to praise God, and to know how and for what to praise him, and with what words? You have Psalms 105, 107, 135, 146, 147, 148 and 150.

Do you have faith, as the Lord said, and do you believe what you say when you pray? Say Psalm 116.

Do you feel yourself climbing upward in what you do, so that you can say, 'Forgetting what lies behind, I strain forward to what lies ahead'? You have, for each step forward, the fifteen Songs of Ascents to sing.

Have you been taken captive by strange thoughts, felt yourself being led away, and repented? Stop there from now on; and, staying where you found yourself sinning, sit down and weep, as the people did then, saying the words of Psalm 137.

If you count your temptations as your testing, and want to give thanks after them, you have Psalm 139.

Are you once more hemmed in by enemies and want to be delivered? Say the words of Psalm 140. Do you

want to make your request and pray? Sing Psalms 5 and 143.

Has an enemy, a tyrant, risen against the people and against you, as Goliath did against David? Do not cower; but believe, as David did, and say the words of Psalm 144.

Then, as you marvel at God's kindness to all, and remember his goodness to you and to everyone, if you want to bless God for it, say the words of David, the very words he spoke in Psalm 145.

Do you want to sing to the Lord? You have Psalms 93 and 98 to say.

If, though you are young, you are chosen over your brothers for some position of leadership, do not lift yourself up over them. Give the glory to the Lord who chose you, and you too sing Psalm 151, which is David's very own.

And if you want to sing psalms that have the Alleluia as their response, you have Psalms 105, 106, 107, 112, 113, 114, 115, 116, 117, 118, 119, 135, 136, 146, 147, 148, 149 and 150.

When you want to sing on your own about the Saviour, you will find such things in almost every psalm. But above all you have Psalms 45 and 110, which show his true birth from the Father and his coming in

the flesh; Psalms 22 and 69, which foretell the divine cross, how great a plot he bore for our sake, and how much he suffered; Psalms 2 and 109, which show the plotting and wickedness of the Jews and the betrayal by Judas Iscariot; and Psalms 21, 50 and 72, which show his kingship and his power to judge, his coming to us again in the flesh, and the calling of the Gentiles. Psalm 16 shows his resurrection from the dead; Psalms 24 and 47 proclaim his going up into heaven; and when you read Psalms 93, 96, 98 and 99, you will be able to see the good things the Saviour has done for us through his sufferings.

This, then, is the character of the Book of Psalms, and how it helps us: it has psalms of its own kind, and in the rest it holds many prophecies of the coming in the body of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ, as I said before.

Why the psalms are sung

Why these words are chanted with melody and song is something we must not pass over either. Some simple people among us, though they believe the words are inspired by God, still think the psalms are set to music for the sake of a pleasing sound and the delight of the ear. It is not so. Scripture did not go looking for what is sweet and attractive. This too has been arranged for

the good of the soul, for every reason, but above all for these two.

First, it was fitting that divine Scripture should praise God not only in continuous speech but also in the full, spacious voice of song. The Law and the Prophets, all the histories, and the New Testament with them, are spoken in continuous speech; but the words of the psalms, hymns and songs are uttered at fuller length. In this way it is made sure that people love God with all their strength and power.

Second, a harmony joins the pipes together and produces a single concord. In the same way, since the soul has different movements in it (it reasons, it desires, it feels the heat of passion) and since the actions of the body's members come from the movement of these, the Word wants a person not to be out of tune with himself, nor divided against himself: not to think what is best, then do evil in a fit of passion, as Pilate did when he said, 'I find no fault in him,' yet went along with the will of the Jews; nor to desire what is evil without being able to do it, like the elders who plotted against Susanna; nor again to refrain from adultery but steal, or refrain from stealing but murder, or refrain from murder but blaspheme. So that no such turmoil may arise in us, the Word wants the soul, having the mind of Christ, as the Apostle said,

to take that mind as its guide; and with it to master the passions within it and to rule the members of the body, so that they obey reason. Then, as the plectrum is to the harp, the person himself, becoming a psaltery and attending wholly to the Spirit, will obey in all his members and movements and serve the will of God.

The tuneful reading of the Psalms is an image and pattern of this calm, unruffled state of the thoughts. For just as we make known and signify the thoughts of the soul by the words we speak, so the Lord, wishing the melody of the words to be a sign of the spiritual harmony in the soul, ordained that the songs be sung with melody and the psalms recited with music. And this is the soul's desire: to be in good order, as it is written, 'Is anyone among you cheerful? Let him sing psalms.' In this way whatever is troubled, rough or disordered in the soul is smoothed out, and what grieves it is healed, as we sing, 'Why are you so sad, my soul, and why do you trouble me?' The soul will recognize where it stumbled, saying, 'My feet had almost slipped'; and what is afraid it will strengthen with hope, saying, 'The Lord is my helper, and I will not fear what anyone can do to me.'

Those who do not read the divine songs in this way do not sing with understanding. They please themselves, but they earn blame, for 'praise is not fitting in the

mouth of a sinner.' But those who sing in the way I have described, so that the melody of the words comes from the rhythm of the soul and its concord with the Spirit, sing with the tongue and sing with the mind as well, and they greatly help not only themselves but also those who are willing to listen. So it was that blessed David, playing in this way before Saul, was himself pleasing to God, and drove away Saul's turmoil and raging passion, and brought his soul to calm. So too the priests, by their singing, called the souls of the people to calm, and to be of one mind with those who dance in heaven.

So the singing of the psalms with melody is not a pursuit of fine sound, but a sign of the harmony of the thoughts within the soul; and the tuneful reading is a symbol of a mind that is well ordered and untroubled by storms. Praising God on well-tuned cymbals, on the harp and on the ten-stringed psaltery was itself a symbol and sign that the members of the body should be rightly ordered like strings, that the thoughts of the soul should become like cymbals, and that all of them together should then move and live by the sound and the bidding of the Spirit; so that, as it is written, a person may live by the Spirit and put to death the deeds of the body. Whoever sings well in this way brings his soul into rhythm and leads it, as it were,

from unevenness to evenness, so that, standing firm in what is according to its nature, it is frightened by nothing, but grows rather in good imaginings, and is seized with greater longing for the good things to come. Brought into tune with the melody of the words, it forgets its passions, and with joy it looks to the mind that is in Christ, thinking on what is best.

Pray them as they are written

So, my child, everyone who takes up this book should read all that is in it faithfully, since it is all inspired by God; and then should gather from it, as fruit from a garden, the help he sees he needs. For I believe that in the words of this book the whole of human life, the dispositions of the soul and the movements of the thoughts, have been measured out and contained, and that nothing more than these is to be found in human beings. Whether one needs repentance or confession; whether trouble and temptation have overtaken him; whether he has been persecuted, or plotted against and rescued; or whether he has become sorrowful and troubled and suffers some such thing as was described above; or whether he sees himself making progress and the enemy brought to nothing; or wants to praise and thank and bless the Lord: he has the teaching for all of these in the divine Psalms. Let him choose what

is said in them about each of these things, and so, speaking it as if written about himself, and taking to heart what is written, let him offer it up to the Lord.

But let no one deck the psalms out with persuasive words from outside, nor try to rework the phrases or change them at all. Let him say and sing what is written simply, just as it was spoken, so that the holy men who served us by giving these words, recognizing them as their own, may pray with us; or rather, so that the Spirit who spoke in the saints, seeing in them the words he himself sounded through them, may help us. For as much as the life of the saints is better than that of others, so much better and stronger, one might rightly say, are their words than the ones we put together. In these words they pleased God, and speaking them, as the Apostle said, 'they conquered kingdoms, did what was right, obtained promises, shut the mouths of lions, quenched the power of fire, escaped the edge of the sword, were made strong out of weakness, became mighty in war, put foreign armies to flight; women received back their dead by resurrection.'

So now let everyone who says these words take courage, for through them God will quickly hear those who ask. If one is afflicted when he says them, he will find great comfort in them. If he is tempted and

persecuted when he sings them, he will come out the more proven, and will be sheltered by the Lord, who sheltered the one who first spoke them. With these words he will overturn the devil and put his demons to flight. If he has sinned, saying these words he will be ashamed and stop; if he has not sinned, he will find himself rejoicing that he is straining toward what lies ahead. Singing in this way, he will be strong in the struggle; he will never be shaken from the truth, but will expose those who deceive and try to lead others astray. And no human being stands surety for this: divine Scripture itself does.

For God commanded Moses to write the great Song and to teach it to the people; and he orders the one appointed as ruler to write out Deuteronomy, to keep it in his hands, and always to meditate on its words, since the words in it are enough to remind us of virtue and to bring help to those who meditate on them faithfully. Indeed, when Joshua the son of Nun entered the land and saw the enemy drawn up, and all the kings of the Amorites gathered for war, instead of weapons and swords he read Deuteronomy aloud in the hearing of all, reminded them of the words of the Law, armed the people with these, and overcame the enemy. King Josiah, when the book had been found and read aloud in the hearing of all, no longer feared his enemies. And

whenever the people were at war, the ark holding the tablets of the Law went before them all, and it was help enough for them in place of any battle line, unless sin and hypocrisy had first gained the upper hand among those who carried it or among the people. For faith and a sincere heart are needed, if the Law is to work with us toward what we pray for.

I myself, said the old man, have heard from wise men that in Israel long ago they drove out demons and exposed the plots the demons lay against people simply by reading the Scriptures. So he said that those who leave these words aside and put together persuasive words of their own from outside, calling themselves exorcists on the strength of them, deserve every condemnation. They are rather playing games, and they make themselves a laughing stock for the demons, as happened to the Jewish sons of Sceva when they too tried to drive out demons in that way. When the demons hear such words from such people, they make sport of them. But the words of the saints they fear, and cannot even bear. For the Lord himself is in the words of the Scriptures; and since they could not bear him, they cried out, ‘I beg you, do not torment me before the time’; for they burned merely at seeing the Lord present. In the same way Paul gave his commands to the unclean spirits, and in the same way the

demons were subject to the disciples. In the days of Elisha the prophet the hand of the Lord came upon him, and he prophesied to the three kings about the waters, while the minstrel played at his command.

So now too, if anyone cares for those who suffer, let him say these words. He will help the sufferer more, and will show his own faith to be true and firm; and God, seeing that faith, will grant complete healing to those who ask. The holy psalmist knew this, and said in Psalm 119, 'I will meditate on your statutes; I will not forget your words'; and again, 'Your statutes have been my songs in the house of my pilgrimage.' For in these words they gained their salvation, saying, 'If your law had not been my meditation, I would have perished in my humiliation.' So Paul too made his own disciple safe with these words, saying, 'Meditate on these things; give yourself to them, so that your progress may be plain to all.'

You too, then, meditate on these things, and read the Psalms with understanding. Then, led by the Spirit, you will be able to grasp the meaning in each one; and you will strive after the same life that was lived by those holy men who, carried by God, first spoke these words.

QUESTIONS FOR REFLECTION

1. The old man calls the Psalter a garden that holds the whole of Scripture in song. Which psalm has carried a story of the Bible for you?
2. Other books we read about other people; the Psalms, he says, we speak as our own words. Which psalm have you prayed as if it had been written about you?
3. The Psalms are "a kind of mirror." What did you last see of yourself in one?
4. Choose one situation from "A psalm for every need" that fits your life this week. Pray the psalm he names, slowly, every day.
5. He wants the psalms said "simply, just as it was spoken," without improvement. Why might borrowed words pray better than our own?
6. Singing, he says, brings a divided soul into tune. Where are your thoughts, desires and actions out of tune with each other?

Psalter. The Book of Psalms; also a stringed instrument (the *psaltery*), which is why the letter can call a person "a psaltery."

Greek Bible (Septuagint). The Greek translation of the Old Testament used by the early Church, from which Athanasius quotes.

Songs of Ascents. Psalms 120-134, sung by pilgrims going up to Jerusalem.

Psalm 151. A short psalm about David's anointing and his fight with Goliath, found in the Greek Bible but not in the Hebrew.

Day of Preparation. Friday, the day before the Sabbath, the day of the crucifixion. The "second" and "fourth" days of the week are Monday and Wednesday.

Catholic Church. The universal Church, as against breakaway groups (schisms) and false teaching (heresies).

Ahithophel. David's counsellor, who joined Absalom's revolt (2 Samuel 15-17).

Ziphites. People of Ziph who told Saul where David was hiding (1 Samuel 23).

Sons of Sceva. Would-be exorcists overpowered by an evil spirit (Acts 19).

Plectrum. The pick used to strike the strings of a harp or lyre.

NOTES

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